

Editorial

It's The Medium, Stupid!

AN INDIAN BLOG died last month, and its readers wept copious tears. It died not because of the blogger's ennui, but because he was served a legal notice by one of India's largest media entities asking him to shut up.

In the larger scheme of things, mediaah.com, an Indian media watchdog blog maintained by Pune-based journalist Pradyuman Maheshwari, was just a blip on the media radar. With a claimed readership of just 8,000 readers, it could have hardly changed the world. Yet, the media conglomerate's bosses decided that they had had enough of Maheshwari's "jibes" at them and their organisation. In March, they sent him a legal notice asking him to delete entries they felt were defamatory.

Maheshwari, on his part, decided to stop publishing the blog, saying he neither has the time nor the money to fight the giant.

He also chose not to apologise.

The media had successfully gagged its toddler cousin, the Web log. Sadly, yet predictably, no newspaper or television channel followed up this story.

Compare this with the case of a slew of bloggers in the US who recently wrote so much about Eason Jordan—a senior CNN executive who allegedly said at the World Economic Forum in Switzerland that the US military had killed 12 journalists by taking deliberate aim—that he had to resign from his post.

No one knows for sure whether he made the statement at all; and no one would say the bloggers themselves were completely ethical in their uproarious response to the statement. Yet, to its credit, CNN never tried to shut these bedroom bloggers up.

Honestly, though, I was delighted at the legal notice sent by India's largest media house to Maheshwari. For one, it bared once and for all the Indian media's hypocritical "Speech-is-free-and-the-media-will-ensure-it-remains-that-way" stand; but more importantly, it proved that Web publishing is here to stay, and that the blog is already an alternate publishing medium in India just as it is in several mature democracies across the world.

When a Rs 1500-crore media giant takes on a one-man blog (Maheshwari's silent capitulation notwithstanding), it is good news. Judging by the response of the blog's readers (many of them on the conglomer-



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ate's rolls), there is a community of readers hungry to know the truth—the reality on the other side.

It is in this community that I have the most faith; the group of people who will effect that much-needed change in our perceptions about the media.

And all because of a phenomenon called the Internet. As common citizens with apolitical agendas, it is technology that will bring us closer to reality. It is a prospect we should all be happy about.

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